



PHOTO BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

BOOM TIME FOR BALM The moving annual total of painkillers and analgesics has increased to ₹13,071 crore in April 2023 from ₹8,894 crore in April 2019, just a year before Covid-19

IN GOOD HEALTH



Demand for pain management and muscle relaxants surged due to post-Covid-19 stress and anxiety after lack of physical activity during the lockdowns



Lingering symptoms of Covid-19, such as body aches and fatigue, have also led people to seek relief through pain management and muscle relaxants



People are getting back to exercising, leading to injuries, which in turn has led to an increase in the use of these medications



The rise of telemedicine during the pandemic has made it easier for people to get prescriptions for these medications



Sales are also being boosted by the fact that hospitals are once again doing surgeries like knee and shoulder replacement following the pandemic

The CAGR numbers relate to the painkillers businesses of these companies in the period 2019-2023.

Similarly, for companies like Cipla with a significant pain management portfolio through Cipla Health—a wholly-owned subsidiary of Cipla Ltd—sales in the pain market have shown moderate growth, with a CAGR of 2.1 per cent over the past five years.

Shivam Puri, CEO of Cipla Health, says, “We have witnessed significant growth in demand for pain care products owing to rising cases of body pain due to the pandemic-induced sedentary lifestyle. Our pain management gel, Omnigel, led the growth in this segment by outgrowing the category by 1.2x.”

Puri says that the household penetration of the category has increased, and the company expects the market to grow further as consumers move towards newer ways of treating their pain. “Understanding consumer needs and introducing innovations based on deep-rooted insights will be the key to growing further in this segment,” he adds.

Meanwhile, Dr. Reddy’s Laboratories—another manufacturer of pain management drugs—has shown consistent growth in sales, with a surge of 19 per cent last year, which indicates a positive trend. In February 2022, Dr. Reddy’s entered into an exclusive sales and distribution agreement with Novartis India Ltd for the Voveran painkiller range, Calcium range and Methergine in India.

“Our business in India has consistently driven strong growth and continues to be a significant focus market for us. Through this agreement, we aim to reinforce our portfolio in pain management and women’s health domains,” says M.V. Ramana, CEO—Branded Markets (India & Emerging Markets), Dr. Reddy’s.

According to a company spokesperson, pain management is a core